



Independent University, Bangladesh

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Assignment Title:

“Analyzing the Features and Responsibilities of the State, and Governance as Outlined by Francis Fukuyama”

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Cover Letter

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Dr. Sultana Razia
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Subject: Group Report on “Governance and Good Governance by Francis Fukuyama”

Dear Ma’am,

We are honored to submit our group report titled “Governance and Good Governance by Francis Fukuyama” for your review and evaluation. This report provides an overview of the concepts of governance and good governance from the perspective of Francis Fukuyama and highlights their relevance to contemporary public administration and policymaking.

In preparing this report, we consulted reliable academic sources and applied the knowledge gained throughout the course. We have made every effort to ensure that the report is accurate, well-organized, and relevant to the topic.

We sincerely appreciate your guidance and support throughout the course. We hope this report meets your expectations. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours sincerely,
Group D

Acknowledgement

We would like to thank Dr. Sultana Razia for her support, feedback and encouragement on this GSG 101 project. We found the insights of Francis Fukuyama, on state, governance invaluable in building our analysis and understanding the real world implications of these issues.

We also appreciate Independent University, Bangladesh for advances library materials and educational resources, and expediting our study to the fullest.

Thirdly thanks for all group members their contribution, hard work and advice helped us to finish this project successfully. This not only helped us collaborate and exchange ideas, but also reinforced our knowledge of this subject matter.

Last but not the least we would like to thank our classmates and colleagues for their constructive discussions and perspectives which helped in refining the analysis and enhancing the quality of this project.

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1. Introduction

1.1 The State

All human societies that are arranged for social living depend on a political order which makes rules, settles disputes, and gives to the members various services (law enforcement being an example) that would otherwise need to be supplied by those people themselves if they were not in such an organised society. This structure is called the state in the field of political science. The state is one of the oldest and most basic concepts in political theory, and learning more about what defines states and how they operate adds clarity to why public life is structured like it is in all but a few places on earth today. A state is more than the government in power; it is a continuous legal and political entity founded on democratic features like (but not only) territory, population, authority, legitimacy, sovereignty and governance, with ongoing obligations to people residing within these borders.

1.2 Governance

Governance, which is the actual exercise of state authority in practice, is intimately tied to the idea of state. The state is the formal organization of a country while governance shows how good, bad or sinister are the decisions that move within such forms. Political economist Francis Fukuyama presents a powerful way of framing governance, whereby the question of how well a government is performing is distinct from that of whether it is democratic at all. According to him actual delivery of goods and services to citizens should dictate governance, —not the kind or type of political system a state has.

There are two basic objectives for the assignment. It first provides a conceptual discussion of the fundamental characteristics of the state and its primary roles to citizens. Secondly, it outlines Fukuyama's framework of governance and good governance, explaining the criteria he employs to evaluate the quality of governance. It is followed by a conclusion that relates state and governance as complementary concepts, closing the report with an analysis critiquing reality based on examples.

2. Description

2.1 The Concept of the State

A state is a politically organized population on the territory over which a government rules with the highest power. The state is different from government and society, and this needs to be clear. The state is a set of legal and political circumstances that exists for all time, the government is just whatever contingent collection of people comprise the governing class of a particular state at a given moment in time, and society is simply the nexus of human relationships throughout history (which need not have anything to do with land or any legal order).

There are two related concepts that fill in the blanks to this story. A nation-state is a state whose citizens or subjects are relatively homogeneous in factors like language or common descent and the definition of this right overlaps, among other reasons, with that of nationalism leading to them being treated together. On the other hand, citizenship is a legal concept of how to be part of a state with specific rights and duties, usually because you were born in or have been nationalised by that state.

2.2 Essential Features of the State

In accordance with the six-feature model of state, for an entity to be recognized as a fully fledged state it needs to have

Territory → An area which a state has complete and internal jurisdiction, including land, internal waters, and airspace.

Population: A population which is a civil and noncivil community within the state, whose officials must exist within the structure of the state.

Authority: The recognized or constitutional right of a state to carry on business or administration over an area and its society.

Legitimacy: When a population and other states recognize that a state has the right to exercise power within its own territory. In contrast, mere control through force is disqualified from governing key aspects of the state and international relations, especially since effectivity derives its legitimacy.

Sovereignty: A fundamental principle that each state has supreme power and is answerable to no higher political or legal force, either at home or abroad.

Governance: The group of institutions, processes and laws by which people conduct the affairs to address the needs of residents in a state (executive, legislature, judiciary and civil service).

A region can easily have population, land and local governance but it is not a state in the full political meaning of this word otherwise.

2.3 Responsibilities of the State

A state not only exists but is supposed to meet certain responsibilities for its citizens. These responsibilities are both the practical rationale for the state's power and the metric of its success or failure:

Law and order: Establishing and maintaining police and the criminal justice system, so that conflicts are resolved peaceably, constitutions more or less followed, citizens feel safe.

Regulatory measures – Any regulations or standards that are in place to address areas like environmental management, food safety, price controls, working conditions, access to alcohol and drugs.

Welfare: Public health care, unemployment benefits, educational subsidies and support for farmers and other vulnerable populations.

Money: Overview Adjustments in money supply and interest rates to ensure an economical balance.

Taxitation: When you collect taxes, and how the public funds spent;

Infrastructure: Delivering and maintaining primary services like roads, schools, water and energy supply.

National Security- military forces to protect the state from external threats.

The question of how well a state performs these functions is fundamentally about governance, a concept I take up next.

2.4 Governance in the philosophy of Francis Fukuyama

Governance, as defined by Francis Fukuyama (2013), is a government capability to enforce rules and provide services. This definition is important because it purposefully separates governance and democracy: Fukuyama has argued that merely having free elections and democratic institutions are not sufficient for a country to be well governed. Rather, it is the real ability of state institutions to fulfil their tasks and respond to citizens concerns that needs to be used together with output data in assessing governance.

Fukuyama points to four broad measures that help to examine the quality of governance, each one revealing a different dimension of the range of governing functions:

Procedural measures: This measure considers the manner in which a government makes decisions, allocates resources and governs -- focusing on process rather than products. By procedural quality, we mean a government with clear and stable rules-based procedures that are properly documented rather than ad hoc or draconian decision making; the recruitment and promotion of staff based on merit as opposed to political patronage; the application of its own rules evenly across cases. Many of the goods-governance tenets Fukuyama has in mind are treated as prima facie indicators (and quite correctly so) of strong procedural quality; each speaks to a different dimension along which the nature and fairness with which a government carries out its process, is measured:

Transparency : Openness in government decisions and of government information was seen as one of the most important criteria by which to measure process quality

Accountability -- Accountability of Officials and institutions is considered by many to be an essential.

Rule of law: An impartial and enforceable judiciary that applies the laws equally to all.

Participation:

Citizens having a real opportunity to engage in the decision making process with respect to government policies.

Efficiency and Effectiveness Public funds are handled by the government and services are delivered in time (Functional responsibility)

Decentralization: Power and responsibility sharing at local levels of government.

Anti corruption: Preventing corruption and misuse of public office.

Public finance management: A strategic approach to budgeting, collection and reporting of public funds.

Input measures: This one looks at the resources a government has available before any service is delivered to exercise its duties in the first place. Common metrics include capacity as an extractor of tax (a.k.a. GNP and GDP), which shows the extent to which a state can really pay for, run, and arm its institutions. Even a government may have the best intentions and super policies, but without money, right skills with trained people and technology it only has the capacity of direct governance. Because of this, input measures are a helpful benchmark: they show what resources a state has at its disposal without conveying anything about what it actually achieves.

Output measures: These evaluate the actual results delivered to citizens -- i.e., the services, infrastructure and benefits that people directly experience (e.g., effective roads, accessible health care and reliable public utilities). Fukuyama believes output is one of the more truthful and transparent indicators of quality governance, as it reflects what a government has actually achieved as opposed to what it may have promised or attempted. Two states may run the same processes and have relatively similar resources but be poles apart in output if one state is better than another at transforming inputs & processes into actual services on the ground.

Bureaucratic autonomy: This indicator examines how independent civil servants and administrative institutions are from short-term political pressures. A bureaucracy with ironclad autonomy can decide based upon professional judgment, hard data and the long-term public good instead of having its few remaining competent civil servants reassigned to more politically desirable jobs every time a new election campaign is fought. Fukuyama says that a truly professional civil service should be able to serve the citizenry repeatedly from one government to another, for it is bureaucratic continuity which allows difficult policies -- like big infrastructure projects or public health programmes -- to be executed successfully over many years. Fukuyama argues that a government which successfully implements these four measures engages in good governance.

3. Critical Analysis with Example

Fukuyama's performance-based definition of governance is useful because it compares countries with quite different political systems against a common, effective yard stick: how well does the government really function? It is this balance of power that checks excesses whether in public or private platform, a useful antidote to definitions of governance that presumes democracy leads to good because it undermines the notion. Some non-democratic states have established large and very competent bureaucracies that provide good public services, as a single example; some democracies suffer from corruption or weak institutions or poor service delivery. The four examples presented below, representing wildly different contexts and political systems, are illustrative of this concept.

3.1 Example: Singapore

Singapore, in particular, is commonly used as a robust example of Fukuyama's model. Ruled by a single powerful political party, it has long been criticized for the degree of genuine competition within its politics but regularly appears as one of the countries least infested with corruption and with impeccable administration. The civil service is seen as professional and largely removed from short-term political pressures: the public housing system works well, so does the healthcare system; and rule of law tends to be applied with remarkable consistency for citizens and businesses alike. Singapore has a very high showing when it is judged simply by output and bureaucratic autonomy, reinforcing Fukuyama's disengagement of governance quality from democratic openness.

3.2 Example: Rwanda

Rwanda provides a similar comparison point from Sub-Saharan Africa. Rwanda has been ruled by a dominant party since the end of the genocide in 1994, with President Paul Kagame's government consistently coming under fire from international observers over its treatment of political opponents. Nonetheless, according to Fukuyama's performance indicators Rwanda has recorded consistent gains: its score of 58 over 100 in the Corruption Perceptions Index 2025 is the highest in East Africa (assisted by digitised public services, an energetic Ombudsman's office and a sustained anti-corruption enforcement effort). The economy has also recovered rapidly, recording growth of nearly 9 per cent in 2024. Countries like Rwanda, similar to Singapore, indicate that even in the absence of competitive democracy material gains from bureaucratic discipline and anti-corruption enforcement are possible.

3.3 Example: Denmark

A useful counter-case is Denmark, with a competitive multiparty democracy yet governance quality that consistently ranks towards the top of global comparisons. Pointed out in last week's post, Denmark + Finland + Singapore = #1 on 2025 Corruption Perceptions Index = Transparency & the Rule of Law with Penalty for Bad Behavior so low it almost reaches zero — GO SEE The experience of Denmark illustrates that democratic engagement and high governance quality are not on the opposite end of a tradeoff — an efficient bureaucracy, a professional civil service, and robust public financial management can go along with free elections. This example complicates facile arguments that non-democratic systems are better-suited to achieve effective governance.

3.4 Example: Democratic republic of the Congo

On the other end of that spectrum, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) proves that bad governance can endure in spite of formal democratic institutions. And the DRC, while it held elections scored a lamentable 20 out of 100 in the first iteration of the updated Corruption Perceptions Index for 2025 — making it one of three low income countries tied with fellow basket cases Somalia and Burundi as the worst performers on this global scorecard. Indeed, despite a stock of formal democratic institutions, weak bureaucratic autonomy coupled with limited public financial management and high levels of corruption have both undermined service delivery and the reservoir of public trust. The DRC reinforces Fukuyama's main thesis: elections alone do not promise a better quality of governance, just as the identification or label “democracy” matters less than how state institutions function on the ground.

3.5 A Critical Counterpoint

All four cases when taken together illustrate the poor fit between governance quality and regime type: Singapore and Rwanda do well without much political competition, Denmark does well with more of it, while the DRC does poorly with relatively little of it. At the same time, Fukuyama's framework — which emphasizes performance — has an important limitation. If governance is based on outputs then commons by nature benefit from both undercounting the long-term benefits of participation and political accountability. Critics say a government can provide efficient services in the short run and still stifle free speech,

opposition or diminish citizens' capacity to correct mistakes made by leaders at the ballot box. In the long run, without participation and transparency to hold decision-makers accountable, issues are created in silence; there are fewer channels (in an institution) through which errors unfold. This is where the case for Denmark is instructive; it seems to imply that perhaps the long-term model must be a combination of more effective outputs with stronger democratic accountability—not treated as mutually exclusive nor alternatives.

3.6 Linking Governance Back to the State

This conversation follows directly from the earlier sections on state features and roles. The six features of the state — territory, population, authority, legitimacy sovereignty and government —tell us what a state is; whereas governance tells us how well the government component of accepted authority is being exercised to serve the population and fulfil its obligations as a state. The six features are formally present in Singapore, Rwanda, Denmark and the DRC but their governments convert that authority into results for people with widely varying degrees of success. In this sense, good governance is what enables the formal authority of the state to be translated into real benefits for citizens — security and welfare, infrastructure, impartiality before the law.

Conclusion

Contemporary states are shaped by: modern states organise public life through the state as political unit, and constituted by six basic elements of which these includes territory, population, authority, legitimacy, sovereignty and government [4]. Then there are features of the state and at it's same time it has certain functions such as maintaining law and order, welfare provision, economic management, national defence, infrastructure development etc.

An important practical dimension to this picture comes from the work of Francis Fukuyama who emphasizes quality of broader governance by not just a degree itself but how well that government actually exercises state power, regardless of its political system and one (indirectly) measured using procedural, input, output, and bureaucratic-autonomy measures. Singapore and Rwanda demonstrate the integration of robust governance performance with institutional discipline without competitive democratic politics, Denmark demonstrates how high democratization and sustained governance quality can co-exist, while the Democratic Republic of the Congo provides a case for the view that elections do

not always lead to good governance. Alongside Denmark, these cases all tend towards Fukuyama's central claim but also remind us of the place of participation and accountability in sustaining governance quality over greater lengths of time. The character of political power is supplied by the state; governance decides how well that power serves people.

5. References

Fukuyama, F. (2013). What is governance? *Governance*, 26(3), 347–368.

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6. Appendix

Table A1: Six Essential Features of the State

Feature	Brief Description
Territory	A geographical area marked by borders.
Population	A permanent population of citizens and non-citizens.
Authority	The acknowledged right of a state to act or to rule.
Legitimacy	Recognition that a state has the right to wield authority within its borders.
Sovereignty	The principle that a state answers to no higher political or legal authority.
Government	The system of institutions, processes, and laws addressing residents' needs.

Table A2: Responsibilities of the State

Responsibility	Focus
Law and order	Police and criminal justice system
Regulation	Standards on environment, food safety, prices, working conditions
Welfare	Healthcare, unemployment benefits, education subsidies, farmer aid
Money	Managing money supply and interest rates
Taxes	Collecting taxes and overseeing public spending
Infrastructure	Roads, schools, water, and energy supply
National security	Maintaining armed forces

Table A3: Fukuyama's Measures of Governance Quality

Measure	Focus
Procedural measures	Process of providing services and ruling — includes transparency, accountability, rule of law, participation, efficiency/effectiveness, decentralization, corruption control, and public financial management
Input measures	Resources such as tax extraction, GNP, and GDP
Output measures	Actual results delivered — infrastructure, resources, health benefits
Bureaucratic autonomy	Civil servants acting professionally, dedicated to citizens rather than pure political mandate